

Managing screaming in neurodivergent children

Spurgeons

Screaming has a purpose
Screaming is not random behaviour.
The goal is not to "stop" the scream, but to
understand it and replace it with a
safer, acceptable alternative.



What is the purpose of screaming ?

- **Communication**
- **Sensory regulation**
- **Escape from stress**
- **Getting attention**

Identify the triggers for screaming

Potential triggers:

Sensory overload

Signs: Covering ears, distress,
too much noise/light/crowds

Sensory seeking (stimming)

Signs: Repetitive, playful
screaming, enjoying the
sound/vibration

Frustration / escape

Signs: Happens during
demands - "This is too
hard/too much"

Attention seeking

Signs: Looks at you while
screaming, wants interaction

Observe their behaviour

What happens before, during,
and after?

**Scan here for
more support**

Replacement behaviours

- The replacement must serve the same function as the scream

Sensory overload

Goal: reduce input and support regulation:

- Create a calm-down space
- Offer noise-cancelling headphones /weighted blanket/ low lighting / quiet corner
- Teach them how to tell you they need a quiet break

Sensory seeking

Goal: provide a safer way to get the same sensation:

- Get them to try a "Whisper phone"/ using tubing
- Suggest they vocalise into a pillow or a plastic container, sound apps or toys
- Try activities (jumping, squeezing, rocking)

Frustration/overwhelm

Goal: Replace with coping and communication

- Teach them to ask for help or a break
- Use deep breathing (practice when calm)
- Sensory reset: try cold water on hands/face.
- **Break** tasks into smaller steps and reduce demand

Attention seeking

Goal: Teach appropriate ways to get attention

- When they scream tap them and say 'excuse me'
- Or ignore the screaming (no eye contact, no response)
- Then immediately respond when they use the correct behaviour

Instead of thinking: 'how do I stop the screaming?', think: 'what is this behaviour trying to achieve?'

- **Behaviour that works will repeat**
- **Behaviour that is replaced will change**

Use positive reinforcement

Reinforce immediately and consistently

Use positive reinforcement

- Catch the exact moment they do the right thing. For example: 'quiet voice, well done!'
- Give an immediate reward (praise, small treat, preferred activity)
- Or try sticker charts or rewards

Prevent screaming before it starts

Prevention reduces 80% of screaming.

- Give warnings before transitions
- Offer choices: 'Bath or reading first?'
- Build regular sensory breaks
- Keep routines predictable

Support Yourself

Screaming can overwhelm you too.

Practical supports:

- Noise-reducing earplugs (e.g. Loop)
- Step back briefly if safe
- Regulate your own breathing

You are your child's regulation anchor

- **Identify the trigger**
- **Choose ONE replacement skill**
- **Teach it when calm**
- **Reinforce immediately**
- **Stay consistent**